

Session 26: Sarah's Tomb as a Mini Eden

Key Takeaways

- Contextually, the cave of Makpelah evokes the idea of the naked pair and garden imagery—an Eden spot.
- Avraham buying the cave is an act of sacrifice, surrender, and hope.
- Biblical authors link Avraham and Sarah's burial site to Eden and to hope for life beyond death.

Sarah's Death and Avraham's Purchase of Burial Cave of Macpelah

Genesis 23:1-2

- Sarah's death in Hebron

Genesis 23:3-16

- **23:3-6** Negotiations with the Hittites: Part 1
- **23:7-11** Negotiations with the Hittites: Part 2
- **23:12-15** Negotiations with the Hittites: Part 3
- **23:16** Avraham buys the field

Genesis 23:17-20

- Sarah's burial in the cave in the field by Hebron

Genesis 23:1-20. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

This story has a very clear symmetrical design. It begins and ends with Sarah's death and burial, told in succinct narrative style. In between these opening and closing frames, there is a long dialogue narrative as Avraham negotiates with the Hittites about a burial plot for his wife and future family. While the story may seem straightforward on a first reading, there are many layers to this story when we notice the network of hyperlinks that connect to the broader themes of the Avraham story as a whole.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 23:1-20

¹ And it was, **the life of Sarah**

^a b one hundred and twenty **years** and seven **years**,
^{a'} the **years** of **the life of Sarah**.

² And **Sarah** **died** in Qiryat-Arba (this is Hebron) in the land of Canaan,
and Avraham went to grieve for **Sarah** and to weep.

³ And Avraham got up from before the face of **his dead one**,
and he spoke to **the sons of Heth** (= Hittites), saying,

⁴ " **I am an immigrant and settler among y'all**,
give me a **burial plot** **as a possession** among y'all,
so I can **bury** **my dead one** from before my face."

⁵ And the Sons of Heth answered Avraham, saying to him,

⁶ " **Listen, our master**.
You are a prince of Elohim in our midst.
Among the choicest of our **burial plots**, **bury** **your dead one**.
No man among us will hold back from you his **burial plot**,
to keep you from **burying** **your dead one**."

⁷ And Avraham got up
and he bowed to the people of the land, to the sons of Heth,

⁸ and he spoke with them, saying
"If it is in your being, the **burying** of **my dead one** before my face,
listen to me,

and approach for me Ephron, the son of Zohar,

⁹ that he would give to me **the cave of Makpelah (= Pairing)** which is his,
which is at the edge of **his field**;
for the full **silver-price** let him give it to me,
in your midst, as a **burial-plot possession**."

¹⁰ And Ephron sat in the midst of the sons of Heth,

and Ephron the Hethite answered Avraham
in the ears of **the sons of Heth**,
of all who were entering the gate of his city, saying,

¹¹ " **No, my master, listen to me**.
I give to you **the field**,
and **the cave** that's in it I give to you,
in the eyes of the sons of my people I give it you,
bury **your dead one**."

¹² And **Avraham bowed before the face of the people of the land**,

¹³ **and he spoke to Ephron in the ears of the people of the land**,
" **Indeed, if only you would listen to me**."

I give you **silver** for **the field** ;
Take it from me,
so I can **bury** **my dead one** there."

14 And Ephron answered Abraham, saying to him,

15 " **My master, listen to me** .

A land, **four hundred shekels of silver** ,
what is that between me and between you?

Bury **your dead one** !"

16 And Abraham listened to Ephron,
and he weighed **the shekels of silver for Ephron** ,
which **he had spoken of in the ears of sons of Heth**:
four hundred shekels of silver ,
by the going of the merchant.

17 **And it was transferred** , **the field** of Ephron
which was in **Makpelah** ,
which was facing **Mamre** ,
the field and the cave which is in it,
and all the trees which are in the field,
which are in all the surrounding border,
18 **to Abraham** as a **possession** ,
in the eyes of **the sons of Heth** ,
along with all who were entering the gate of his city.

19 Now, after this, Abraham **buried** Sarah his wife,
in **the cave of the field of Makpelah** ,
which was facing **Mamre** (this is Hebron),
in the land of Canaan.

20 **And it was transferred** ,
the field and the cave which was in it,
to Abraham as a **burial-plot** **possession** ,
from **the sons of Heth** .

Genesis 23:1-20. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Burial Plots, Rivqah, and God's Blessing

The sequence of stories in Genesis 22-25 may seem odd, but there is an important thematic development as we pass from the generation of Abraham to that of Yitskhaq. This is signaled by the presence of a network of

key words that relate to each other through wordplay association.

Genesis 22:1-19	Genesis 22:20-24	Genesis 23	Genesis 24	Genesis 25
"Blessing" <i>berak / berakah</i> ברכה / ברך	"Rivqah" <i>rivqah</i> רבקה	"Burial / bury" <i>qevurah / qavar</i> קבר / קבורה	Rivqah / blessing <i>rivqah / berakah</i> ברכה / רבקה	Blessing / burial <i>berak / qavar</i> קבר / ברך
Gen. 22:17 "I will ble ss you and I will multiply your seed like the stars of the skies ... and it will possess the gate of its enemies ."	Gen. 22:23 "And Bethuel caused the birth of Rivqah ."	Gen. 23:19 "Avraham buried Sarah in the cave of Machpelah." Note: The bartering scene takes place "in the gate of the city ." (Gen. 23:10, 18)	Gen. 24:60 "And they blessed Rivqah , (ויברכו ... רבקה) 'You are our sister, may you become ten thousand! And may your seed possess the gate of its enemies .'"	Gen. 25:10-11 "And Avraham's sons buried him in the cave of Machpelah ... And after the death of Avraham, Elohim blessed Yitskhaq his son."
Key Words in Genesis 22-25. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).				

The blessing (*berakah*) of Avraham is passed onto his son in the form of Rivqah, with whom he will have children. God's blessing (*berakah*) to Avraham of possessing the land first takes place in the burial (*qavar*) of Sarah. Rivqah is given the same blessing (*berakah*) of future seed that will inherit the land.

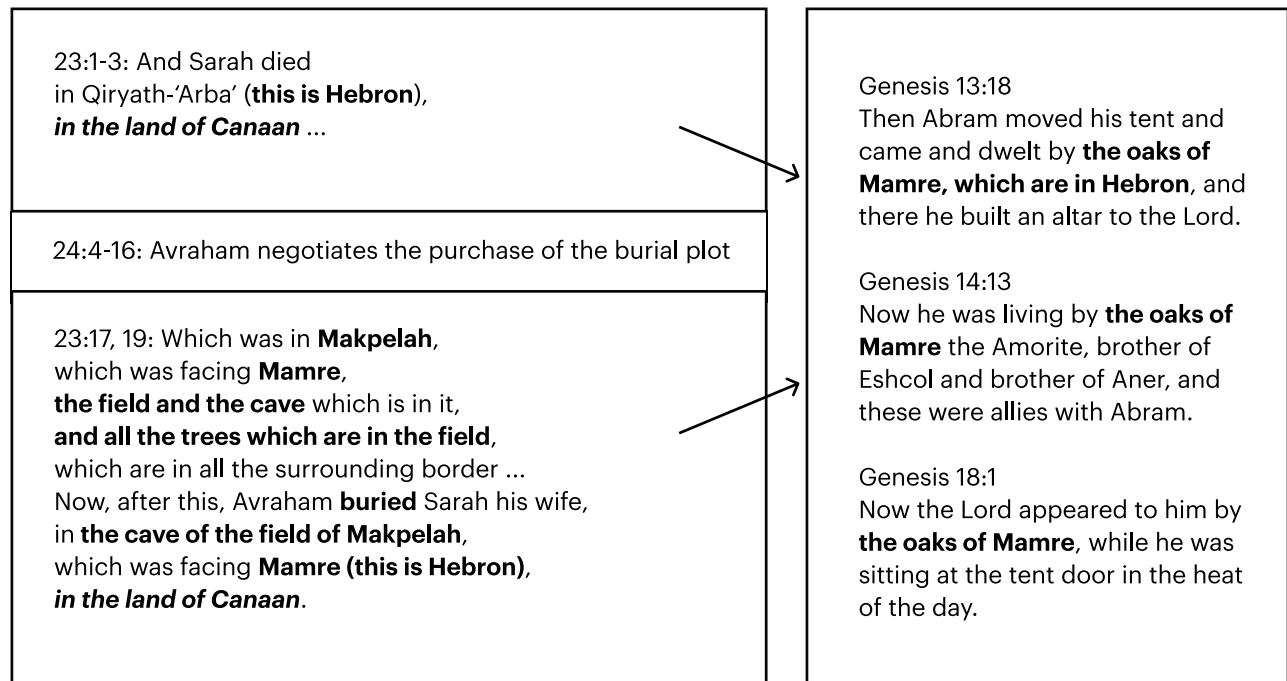
This interconnected series of narratives makes one thing clear: The death of God's chosen ones does not prevent God from continuing his purpose to bless.

Death, Paradise, and the Passing of the Righteous

The story of Sarah's burial is a full-scale replay of the core themes at work in the garden of Eden story. Through wordplays, hyperlinks, and narrative analogies, Avraham's loss of Sarah is compared to both the loss of eternal life in Eden and to the hope of God's promise to restore life.

The Death of the Beloved by the Sacred Tree

After Avraham's great act of faithfulness, we're told that his beloved wife dies near the sacred tree where Avraham had encamped all the way back in [Genesis 14](#). The design of this story emphasizes the importance of this location by repeating the mention of Hebron in the opening and closing of the chapter.



Death by the Sacred Tree. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

The narrative highlights that when Avraham is living near Hebron/Mamre, it is by trees that he lived, worshipped, and met with God. This is a clear Eden motif, as Avraham and Sarah are presented as a new Adam and Eve living in the promised garden land and communing with God by the trees of Hebron.

Sadly, the wife of the new Adam eventually dies by the sacred trees of Mamre. This is a vivid and potent image that recalls the woman eating from the tree that leads to death. But it is also by the sacred trees of Mamre/Hebron that Sarah is buried.

“Dusty” Ephron, and the Hope of Eternal Life

The name of Avraham’s Hittite negotiating partner is Ephron, from the Hebrew word for “dust” (*‘aphar* / עפר). This creates the humorous image of Avraham bartering with “Dusty” to ensure a place of rest for his beloved.

Recall that “death unto the dust” is a key image from the Eden narrative that’s associated with death.

Genesis 3:19 Instructor’s Translation

By the sweat of your face you will eat bread,
until you return to the ground,
because from it you were taken;
for you are **dust** (*‘aphar*)
and to **dust** (*‘aphar*) you shall return.

The Cave of the “Naked Pair”

Both of the words “cave” and “Makpelah” have rich wordplay associations with the Eden story.

“Cave” (*me’arah* / מערה) in Hebrew literally means “place of exposure/nakedness.” This Hebrew noun is related to two root words spelled with similar letters that both mean “to be exposed, naked” (ערר / *’arar*, see [Isa. 32:11](#) and עור / *’ur*, see [Hab. 3:9](#)) and is spelled with the same letters as “nakedness” from [Genesis 2:25](#).

Genesis 2:25 Instructor’s Translation

And they were naked (*’arom* / ערום) and they were not ashamed.

Genesis 23:9 Instructor’s Translation

that he would give to me the cave (*me’arah* / מערה) ...

“Makpelah” is an odd place name that means “doubling” or “pair.” The root is *kaphal* (כפל) which means “to be doubled” or “paired” (see examples of the verb in [Exod. 26:9](#); [Ezek. 21:19](#)).

The meaning of Makpelah as “pair” or “double” is attested early in the history of Jewish interpretation because the Greek Septuagint translators rendered this word with *το διπλουν* (“twin” or “paired”).

When these curious words are combined, the name of this place is The Nakedness of the Pair. This is a clever reference back to the moment when Adam and Eve violate God’s command, eat from the forbidden fruit, and then realize that “the two of them are naked” ([Gen. 2:24-25](#) and [3:6-7](#)).

The Burial Plot as Avraham’s Mini-Eden

The description of the cave and the burial plot in [Genesis 23:17-18](#) is repetitious and unnecessarily wordy because it repeats vocabulary from earlier in the chapter. Upon closer inspection, however, these repetitions seem intentional and create a series of hyperlinks back to earlier moments in the Avraham narrative where the promised land was set on analogy to Eden.

Genesis 23:17-18

"And it was transferred, the field of Ephron (עפרון) which is by Makpelah, **which is in front of Mamre** (לפני ממרא) ..."

Hyperlinks to Earlier Genesis Narratives

Gen. 13:10-11 "Lot lifted up his eyes and saw all the valley of the Jordan, **all watered ... like the garden of God, before Yahweh destroyed Sodom and Gomorrah** . And Lot chose for himself all the valley of the Jordan ... and they **separated** (יפרדו)."

Gen. 13:14-15, 18 "Yahweh said to Avram after Lot **separated** (הפרד) from him, 'Lift up your eyes and see ... north, south, east, west ... I give it to you and your seed forever, and I will make your seed like the dust (עפר) of the earth.' And Avram tented and dwelt among the **oaks of Mamre** ."

*In Genesis 13, Lot’s choices of Sodom as a false-Eden was set in

Avraham’s Mini Eden. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Genesis 23:17-18	Hyperlinks to Earlier Genesis Narratives
	contrast to Avraham's choice of the promised land, specifically "the oaks of Mamre" which is God's gift of Eden to Avraham.
"... The field and the cave which is in it, and all the trees which are in (כל העץ אשר ב) the field ..."	Gen. 1:29 "And God said to the human, 'Behold I have given to you every plant bearing seed which is on the face of the land, and all the trees which are in it (כל העץ אשר ב)." Gen. 2:9 "And Yahweh caused to sprout from the ground all the trees (כל עץ) that are desirable to look at."
"... which is in all its border around (בכל ... סביב) to Avraham as a possession (למקנה) in the eyes of the sons of Heth, with all who enter the gate of his city."	Gen. 2:10-14 "And a river went out from Eden to water (שקה) the garden, and from there it separated (יפרד) ... the Pishon it went all around (סבב) ... the Gihon it went all around (סבב) ..." Gen. 10:15, 19 "And Canaan bore Sidon his firstborn and Heth ... And the border of the Canaanite was from Sidon as you go ... to Sodom and Gomorrah."
<i>Avraham's Mini Eden. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).</i>	

Avraham's burial plot is described as a tiny refuge for the "naked pair" that is located in the middle of a field filled with trees, namely the sacred trees of Mamre. We couldn't ask for a more rich and creative set of allusions back to the garden of Eden.

Avraham's First Possession of the Land

The description of the cave, trees, and field of Makpelah as Avraham's first actual "possession" ('akhuzzah / אחזה) of the promised land is highly significant. This Eden-like field and burial plot marks the first step in Avraham's family taking possession of the land. This word "possession" links back to God's promises to Avraham, and it will go on to have a significant role in the later narratives of the Israelites taking possession of the land.

God's Promise of the Land as a Possession

Genesis 17:7-8 NASB*

⁷ I will establish my covenant between me and you and your descendants after you throughout their generations for an everlasting covenant, to be God to you and to your descendants after you. ⁸ I will give to you and to your descendants after you, the land of your sojournings, all the land of Canaan, **as an everlasting possession** (לאחזה) and I will be their God.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Avraham's First Possession of the Land

Genesis 23:20 Instructor's Translation

And it was transferred, the field and the cave which was in it, to Avraham **as a possession** (לְאִחְזָה) of a burial plot from the sons of Heth.

Later Descriptions of the Land as a Possession

Deuteronomy 32:48-49 NASB*

⁴⁸ The LORD spoke to Moses that very same day, saying, ⁴⁹ "Go up to this mountain of the Abarim, Mount Nebo, which is in the land of Moab opposite Jericho, and look at the land of Canaan, which I am giving to the sons of Israel **as a possession** (לְאִחְזָה)."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Joshua 22:4 NASB*

And now the LORD your God has given rest to your brothers, as he spoke to them; therefore turn now and go to your tents, to the land of your **possession** (אִחְזָה), which Moses the servant of the LORD gave you beyond the Jordan.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 2:7-8 NASB*

⁷ I will surely tell of the decree of the LORD: he said to me, "You are my son, today I have begotten you. ⁸ Ask of me, and I will surely give the nations as your inheritance, and the very ends of the earth **as your possession** (אִחְזָה)."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Description of the Future Messiah's Inheritance

Amos 9:11-12 NASB*

In that day I will raise up the fallen tent of David, and wall up its breaches; I will also raise up its ruins and rebuild it as in the days of old; That they may **possess** the remnant of Edom, and all the nations who are called by my name ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Obadiah 15, 17, 21 NASB

¹⁵ For the day of the LORD draws near on all the nations ... ¹⁷ But on Mount Zion there will be those who escape, And it will be holy. And the house of Jacob will **possess their possessions** ... ²¹ The deliverers will ascend Mount Zion, to judge the mountain of Esau, And the kingdom will be the LORD's.

In this narrative, the field and the cave of Makpelah become a "down payment" of the future inheritance of Israel and ultimately of the Messiah's reign over all nations. The hyperlinks that set this field on analogy with Eden also open the wider associations between this story and Avraham's possession of the new creation

through his messianic family. It is this network of scriptural associations that led Paul the apostle to say what he did in Romans 4:13.

Romans 4:13 NASB*

For the promise to Abraham or to his seed that he would **be inheritor of the world** was not through the Law, but through the righteousness of faith.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Reflection Question

In what way is Avraham's purchase of the cave from Ephron an act of sacrifice, surrender, and hope? How does the story show us this?